



MONEY YOU'RE OWED

Airline & Travel Refund Toolkit

CLAIM WHAT'S RIGHTFULLY YOURS

The official process is always free. This kit doesn't sell you secrets — it's the done-for-you implementation: fill-in letters, word-for-word scripts, and trackers that save you the hours. Every method is built on official 2026 U.S. rules (DOT, IRS, CFPB, FDIC, state programs).

Airline & Travel Refund Toolkit

Money You're Owed — the done-for-you paperwork that gets your money back.

One-line promise: Fill in the blanks, send the letter, track the claim — and collect the refund or compensation the law already says is yours.

This is implementation, not a secret. The official process is always FREE.

You never have to pay anyone — not us, not a "claims service," not a "finder" — to get an airline refund or compensation. Every form, complaint portal, and demand letter described here is free to use directly with the airline and the U.S. Department of Transportation (DOT). What you are paying \$17 for is the *done-for-you* part: the exact letters, the word-for-word phone scripts, and the tracker, so you don't have to write any of it from scratch or guess which rule applies. If a "service" ever offers to claim your refund for a percentage, you can do the same thing yourself for free using this toolkit.

How to use this toolkit (read this first)

1. **Figure out what happened to you**, then jump to the matching asset using the table of contents below.
2. **Open the asset.** Each one starts with a *When/how to use this* header and a *What law backs it* note, so you know it fits your situation before you send anything.
3. **Replace every [BRACKETED PLACEHOLDER]** with your details. Do not leave brackets in the final letter.
4. **Send it the paper-trail way.** Use the airline's official complaint form or customer-service email so you have a timestamp and a written record. Keep copies of everything.
5. **Log it in the Claim Tracker** (Asset 09 / the CSV) so deadlines don't slip.
6. **If the airline stalls or says no, escalate to the DOT** using Asset 06. The DOT complaint is free and airlines are required to respond.

The 60-second decision guide

What happened	Go to
Airline canceled your flight, or changed it so much you didn't fly	Asset 01 — Cancellation / Significant-Change Refund
Flight was significantly delayed or the schedule moved more than 3 hrs (domestic) / more than 6 hrs (intl) and you chose not to travel	Asset 02 — Significant-Delay / Schedule-Change Refund

What happened	Go to
Your checked bag was delayed past the cutoff and you paid a bag fee	Asset 03 — Checked-Bag Delay Fee Refund
You paid for a service you didn't get (Wi-Fi, paid seat, lounge, early boarding)	Asset 04 — Ancillary-Fee Refund
You need to call or chat the airline and want a script	Asset 05 — Phone / Chat Customer-Service Script
The airline won't refund you and you want to escalate	Asset 06 — DOT Complaint Template
You were bumped / denied boarding on an oversold flight	Asset 07 — Denied-Boarding Compensation Claim
Your flight departed the EU , or was an EU airline into the EU, and was delayed/canceled	Asset 08 — EU261 Claim Letter
You want to track multiple claims	Asset 09 — Claim Tracker (+ <code>claim-tracker.csv</code>)

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- **01 — Cancellation / Significant-Change Refund Letter**
- **02 — Significant-Delay / Schedule-Change Refund Letter**
- **03 — Checked-Bag Delay Fee Refund Letter**
- **04 — Ancillary-Fee Refund Letter** (paid service not provided)
- **05 — Airline Phone / Chat Customer-Service Script**
- **06 — US DOT Complaint Submission Template**
- **07 — Denied-Boarding / Bumping Compensation Claim Letter**
- **08 — EU261 Claim Letter** (transatlantic / EU-departing flights)
- **09 — Claim Tracker** (table + importable `claim-tracker.csv`)

The four things every claim needs

Before you send any letter, have these ready. They go in almost every placeholder:

1. **Confirmation / record locator** (6-character booking code) and **ticket number** (13 digits).
2. **Flight details**: airline, flight number, date, scheduled vs. actual times, route.
3. **Amount and form of payment**: what you paid, on what card or method.

4. **What you want:** a *refund to your original form of payment* (cash-equivalent), not a voucher or travel credit — unless you actually want the credit.
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Plain-English summary of the laws this toolkit uses (2026)

You do not need to memorize these — each asset cites the right one for you. This is just the lay of the land.

- **DOT Automatic Refund Rule (14 CFR Part 260).** Since October 28, 2024, U.S. and foreign airlines must **automatically refund** you — to your **original form of payment (cash-equivalent), not a voucher** — when they cancel or significantly change your flight and you don't accept the alternative, when a checked bag is significantly delayed, or when you paid for a service the airline didn't provide. Refunds are due within **7 business days** (credit card) or **20 calendar days** (other payment). A "significant change" is a departure/arrival shift of **more than 3 hours** for domestic flights or **more than 6 hours** for international flights, plus certain other changes like an airport change, added connections, or a downgrade.
- **Denied-Boarding Compensation (14 CFR Part 250).** If you're involuntarily bumped from an oversold flight, you're owed cash compensation. As of January 22, 2025 the caps are **\$1,075** (shorter delays) and **\$2,150** (longer delays), based on how late the airline gets you to your destination.
- **Baggage rules (14 CFR Part 254 + Part 260).** Bag fees are refundable when a checked bag is significantly delayed. The domestic baggage **liability limit** is **\$4,700** per passenger (effective January 22, 2025) for lost/damaged/delayed-bag losses.
- **EU Regulation 261/2004.** For flights **departing an EU/EEA airport (any airline)**, or arriving in the EU **on an EU airline**, long delays (3+ hrs at arrival), cancellations, and denied boarding can trigger fixed cash compensation of **€250 / €400 / €600** by distance — separate from, and on top of, any U.S. refund.

Laws change. These figures are current as of June 2026. The DOT consumer pages ([transportation.gov/airconsumer](https://www.transportation.gov/airconsumer)) are the live source of truth.

01 — Cancellation / Significant-Change Refund Letter

When/how to use this

Use this when the **airline canceled your flight**, or made a **significant change** to it, and you did **not** fly — either because you rejected the rebooking they offered, or they never got you where you were going. This is the letter that demands your money back to your **original form of payment**, not a voucher or travel credit.

A "significant change" includes: - Departure time moved **more than 3 hours earlier** (domestic) or **more than 6 hours** (international) - Arrival time moved **more than 3 hours later** (domestic) or **more than 6 hours** (international) - A **change in departure or arrival airport** - An **added connection / extra stop** - A **downgrade** to a lower class of service - A switch to a **less accessible** aircraft (for passengers with disabilities)

Send it by the airline's official complaint/refund web form **and** email so you have a timestamped paper trail. Then log it in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09).

What law backs it

DOT Automatic Refund Rule — 14 CFR Part 260 (compliance date October 28, 2024). When a U.S. or foreign air carrier cancels or significantly changes a flight to, from, or within the U.S. and the passenger does not accept rebooking or other compensation, the airline must issue an **automatic refund** of the unused ticket and any extra fees, **to the original form of payment (cash-equivalent), not a voucher**. Refunds are due within **7 business days** for credit-card purchases and **20 calendar days** for other payment forms. Refunds must include all government-imposed taxes and airline fees, minus the value of any travel actually used.

LETTER

To: [AIRLINE NAME] — Refunds / Customer Relations **Submitted via:** [AIRLINE OFFICIAL REFUND FORM URL] and [REFUND/CUSTOMER-RELATIONS EMAIL] **Date:** [DATE]

Passenger name: [YOUR FULL NAME, exactly as on the ticket] **Confirmation / record locator:** [6-CHARACTER CODE] **Ticket number(s):** [13-DIGIT TICKET NUMBER(S)]
Frequent-flyer #: [IF ANY]

Flight affected: - Route: [ORIGIN AIRPORT] → [DESTINATION AIRPORT] - Flight number: [FLIGHT NUMBER] - Original scheduled date/time: [DATE] at [TIME] - What happened: [☐ flight was canceled / ☐ flight was significantly changed] - Details of the change: [e.g., "departure

moved from 8:00 AM to 1:30 PM, a 5.5-hour delay" OR "the only rebooking offered arrived the next day"]

To whom it may concern,

My flight identified above was [canceled / significantly changed] by [AIRLINE NAME]. I was either not offered acceptable alternative transportation or I declined the alternative offered, and I did not accept a travel credit, voucher, or other compensation in place of a refund.

Under the U.S. Department of Transportation's Automatic Refund Rule (**14 CFR Part 260**), when an airline cancels or significantly changes a flight to, from, or within the United States and the passenger does not accept rebooking, a travel credit, or a voucher, the airline is required to issue a prompt, **automatic refund to the original form of payment** for the unused portion of the ticket, including all government-imposed taxes and fees and all airline-imposed fees. I am requesting that refund now.

I paid [**\$ AMOUNT**] by [**ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT — e.g., Visa ending 4321 / debit card / PayPal / airline miles**] on [**PURCHASE DATE**]. I am requesting a **full refund to that original form of payment**. I am **not** requesting and will **not** accept a travel voucher or credit in place of this cash-equivalent refund.

The rule requires this refund to be issued promptly — within **7 business days** if I paid by credit card, or within **20 calendar days** for any other form of payment. Please confirm in writing that the refund has been processed and provide the refund reference number.

If I do not receive a confirmation and refund within the timeframe above, I will file a complaint with the U.S. Department of Transportation Office of Aviation Consumer Protection.

Thank you for your prompt attention.

[YOUR FULL NAME] [YOUR EMAIL] [YOUR PHONE] [YOUR MAILING ADDRESS]

After you send it

- **Save** the confirmation page / auto-reply email.
- **Set a deadline** in the Claim Tracker: 7 business days (credit card) or 20 calendar days (other).
- **If they offer a voucher**, reply in writing: *"I decline the voucher and am requesting a refund to my original form of payment as required under 14 CFR Part 260."*
- **If they miss the deadline or refuse**, escalate with Asset 06 (DOT complaint).

02 — Significant-Delay / Schedule-Change Refund Letter

When/how to use this

Use this when the airline **delayed or rescheduled** your flight by enough that you **chose not to travel** and want your money back. The trigger is the same "significant change" standard as a cancellation: a shift of **more than 3 hours** (domestic) or **more than 6 hours** (international) in departure or arrival time, an airport change, an added stop, or a downgrade.

Important distinction: U.S. law does **not** pay you a fixed cash penalty just because a flight was late (that's an EU261 thing — see Asset 08). What U.S. law *does* require is a **full refund of your fare** if the change is "significant" and you decide not to fly. So this letter is for travelers who said *"that delay/reschedule no longer works for me — give me my money back,"* not for travelers who flew anyway and want a delay bonus.

If you **already flew** despite the delay, you are generally not owed a U.S. refund — but check Asset 04 if you also paid for a service you didn't receive, and Asset 08 if the flight touched the EU.

What law backs it

DOT Automatic Refund Rule — 14 CFR Part 260. A "significant change of flight itinerary" includes a departure time advanced, or an arrival time delayed, by **more than 3 hours for a domestic flight** or **more than 6 hours for an international flight**, a change of origin/destination airport, an added connection, a downgrade, or a change to a less accessible aircraft. If the passenger does not accept rebooking, a voucher, or a credit, the airline must issue an **automatic refund to the original form of payment (cash-equivalent)** within **7 business days** (credit card) or **20 calendar days** (other), including taxes and fees.

LETTER

To: [AIRLINE NAME] — Refunds / Customer Relations **Submitted via:** [AIRLINE OFFICIAL REFUND FORM URL] and [REFUND/CUSTOMER-RELATIONS EMAIL] **Date:** [DATE]

Passenger name: [YOUR FULL NAME, exactly as on the ticket] **Confirmation / record locator:** [6-CHARACTER CODE] **Ticket number(s):** [13-DIGIT TICKET NUMBER(S)]

Flight affected: - Route: [ORIGIN] → [DESTINATION] (this is a [☐ domestic / ☐ international] flight) - Flight number: [FLIGHT NUMBER] - Originally scheduled: depart [DATE/TIME], arrive [DATE/TIME] - Revised by the airline to: depart [NEW DATE/TIME], arrive [NEW DATE/TIME] - Size of the change: [e.g., "arrival moved 4 hours 20 minutes later"]

To whom it may concern,

[AIRLINE NAME] made a significant change to the flight identified above. The [departure / arrival] time was moved by **[X hours Y minutes]**, which exceeds the threshold for a "significant change of flight itinerary" under DOT rules — **more than 3 hours for a domestic flight, or more than 6 hours for an international flight** [delete whichever does not apply]. [If applicable: The change also involved [an airport change / an added connection / a downgrade].]

This change did not work for my travel plans. I did **not** accept the revised itinerary, and I did **not** accept a travel credit, voucher, or other compensation.

Under the U.S. Department of Transportation's Automatic Refund Rule (**14 CFR Part 260**), when an airline significantly changes a flight to, from, or within the United States and the passenger declines the alternative, the airline must issue a prompt, **automatic refund to the original form of payment**, including all taxes and fees. I am requesting that refund now.

I paid **[\$ AMOUNT]** by **[ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT]** on **[PURCHASE DATE]**. Please refund the full amount to that original form of payment. I am **not** requesting a voucher or travel credit.

Please process this refund within the required timeframe — **7 business days** (credit card) or **20 calendar days** (other payment) — and confirm in writing with a refund reference number.

If the refund is not issued within that window, I will file a complaint with the U.S. DOT Office of Aviation Consumer Protection.

Sincerely,

[YOUR FULL NAME] [YOUR EMAIL] [YOUR PHONE] [YOUR MAILING ADDRESS]

After you send it

- Screenshot the **original** schedule and the **revised** schedule (the email or app notification proving the size of the change). That timestamped proof is your whole case.
- Log the deadline in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09).
- If they push a voucher, decline in writing and cite 14 CFR Part 260.
- No response or a refusal → Asset 06 (DOT complaint).

03 — Checked-Bag Delay Fee Refund Letter

When/how to use this

Use this when you **paid a checked-bag fee** and the airline delivered your bag **late** — past the legal cutoff. You're owed your **bag fee back**. (This is separate from any claim for the *value* of delayed/lost contents; see the note at the bottom.)

The cutoffs that trigger your bag-fee refund: - **Domestic flight:** bag not delivered within **12 hours** of the flight arriving at the gate. - **International flight 12 hours or shorter:** bag not delivered within **15 hours** of arrival. - **International flight longer than 12 hours:** bag not delivered within **30 hours** of arrival.

Required first step: You must **file a mishandled-baggage report** with the airline (at the airport baggage office, or online/phone right after). The refund right is tied to that report. Get the file/reference number — you'll need it below.

What law backs it

DOT Automatic Refund Rule — 14 CFR Part 260. Airlines must refund the checked-bag fee when a bag is "**significantly delayed**" — defined as not delivered within **12 hours (domestic)**, **15 hours (international flights of 12 hours or less)**, or **30 hours (international flights over 12 hours)** after arrival — provided the passenger filed a mishandled-baggage report. (Separately, the domestic baggage **liability limit** under **14 CFR Part 254** is **\$4,700** per passenger for the actual value of lost/damaged/delayed baggage, effective January 22, 2025.)

LETTER

To: [AIRLINE NAME] — Baggage Service / Customer Relations **Submitted via:** [AIRLINE OFFICIAL BAGGAGE-CLAIM / REFUND FORM URL] and [EMAIL] **Date:** [DATE]

Passenger name: [YOUR FULL NAME] **Confirmation / record locator:** [6-CHARACTER CODE] **Ticket number:** [13-DIGIT TICKET NUMBER] **Mishandled-baggage / file reference number:** [PIR / FILE REFERENCE FROM YOUR REPORT]

Flight & bag details: - Route: [ORIGIN] → [DESTINATION] (this was a [☐ domestic / ☐ international] flight; flight duration [HOURS]) - Flight number: [FLIGHT NUMBER] - Arrival at gate: [DATE] at [TIME] - Bag actually delivered: [DATE] at [TIME] → delay of [**X hours**] - Checked-bag fee paid: [**\$ AMOUNT**] on [**ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT**]

To whom it may concern,

I am requesting a refund of the **checked-bag fee** I paid on the flight above. My checked bag was significantly delayed: it arrived **[X hours]** after my flight reached the gate, which exceeds the DOT threshold for a significantly delayed bag — **12 hours for a domestic flight, 15 hours for an international flight of 12 hours or less, or 30 hours for an international flight longer than 12 hours** [keep the one that applies].

I filed a mishandled-baggage report at/after arrival; the reference number is **[FILE REFERENCE]**.

Under the U.S. Department of Transportation's Automatic Refund Rule (**14 CFR Part 260**), the checked-bag fee for a significantly delayed bag must be **refunded to the original form of payment**. I paid **[\$ AMOUNT]** by **[ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT]**. Please refund that amount to my original form of payment and confirm in writing with a refund reference number.

[Optional — only if you also had out-of-pocket losses: In addition to the bag-fee refund, my delayed bag caused documented expenses of **[\$ AMOUNT]** for [necessary replacement items]. Receipts are attached. I am submitting these for reimbursement under the carrier's baggage-liability obligations (domestic limit \$4,700 per passenger under 14 CFR Part 254).]

If the bag-fee refund is not processed promptly, I will file a complaint with the U.S. DOT Office of Aviation Consumer Protection.

Sincerely,

[YOUR FULL NAME] [YOUR EMAIL] [YOUR PHONE] [YOUR MAILING ADDRESS]

Attachments: [bag-fee receipt], [mishandled-baggage report], [delivery confirmation showing date/time], [receipts for replacement items, if claiming].

After you send it

- The **bag-fee refund** and the **value-of-contents claim** are two different things. The bag fee is owed automatically once the delay crosses the cutoff and you filed a report. The contents/expenses claim is a separate negotiation capped at **\$4,700** (domestic) and requires receipts.
- Keep the delivery confirmation that shows the **exact delivery time** — that's what proves you crossed the cutoff.
- Log it in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09). No response → Asset 06 (DOT complaint).

04 — Ancillary-Fee Refund Letter (paid service not provided)

When/how to use this

Use this when you **paid extra for a service the airline did not provide**. Common examples: - **Wi-Fi** you bought but that didn't work the whole flight - A **paid seat assignment** (extra legroom, preferred seat) you were moved out of - **Priority / early boarding** you paid for but weren't given - **Lounge access**, in-flight **entertainment**, or a **meal** you prepaid and didn't receive - A **seat upgrade** you paid for, then got downgraded

If the airline didn't deliver the thing you paid for, that fee is refundable to your original form of payment. This is one of the clearest, fastest wins in the toolkit.

What law backs it

DOT Automatic Refund Rule — 14 CFR Part 260. Airlines must **automatically refund fees paid for ancillary services** (such as Wi-Fi, seat selection, or in-flight entertainment) **when the airline fails to provide the service**. The refund must go to the **original form of payment (cash-equivalent)**, not a voucher, and must be issued promptly — **7 business days** (credit card) or **20 calendar days** (other payment).

LETTER

To: [AIRLINE NAME] — Customer Relations / Refunds **Submitted via:** [AIRLINE OFFICIAL REFUND FORM URL] and [EMAIL] **Date:** [DATE]

Passenger name: [YOUR FULL NAME] **Confirmation / record locator:** [6-CHARACTER CODE] **Ticket number:** [13-DIGIT TICKET NUMBER]

Service not provided: - Flight: [FLIGHT NUMBER], [ORIGIN] → [DESTINATION], [DATE] - Service I paid for: [e.g., "in-flight Wi-Fi day pass" / "Economy Plus seat 12C" / "Priority boarding"] - Amount paid: **[\$ AMOUNT]** on **[ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT]**, purchased **[DATE]** - What happened: [e.g., "Wi-Fi never connected for the entire 3-hour flight" / "I was reassigned from my paid extra-legroom seat to a standard middle seat" / "priority boarding was not offered and I boarded with the general group"]

To whom it may concern,

I paid **[\$ AMOUNT]** for **[SERVICE]** on the flight above, and the airline **did not provide** that service. [One sentence of specifics, e.g., "The Wi-Fi I purchased failed to connect for the entire

flight," or "I was moved out of the extra-legroom seat I paid for and placed in a standard economy seat."]

Under the U.S. Department of Transportation's Automatic Refund Rule (**14 CFR Part 260**), when an airline fails to provide a paid ancillary service, it must issue a **refund of that fee to the original form of payment**. I am requesting a full refund of **[\$ AMOUNT]** to **[ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT]**. I am **not** requesting a voucher, travel credit, or miles in place of this refund.

Please process the refund promptly — within **7 business days** (credit card) or **20 calendar days** (other payment) — and confirm in writing with a refund reference number.

If the refund is not issued, I will file a complaint with the U.S. DOT Office of Aviation Consumer Protection.

Sincerely,

[YOUR FULL NAME] [YOUR EMAIL] [YOUR PHONE] [YOUR MAILING ADDRESS]

Attachments: [receipt for the paid service], [boarding pass / seat map showing what you paid for], [any photo or note documenting the failure, e.g., a screenshot of the Wi-Fi error].

After you send it

- Document the failure **in the moment** when you can: a photo of the dead Wi-Fi portal, a note of the flight attendant's name who reseated you, a screenshot of your original paid seat. This is what turns a "he said / she said" into an easy approval.
- Log it in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09). No response → Asset 06 (DOT complaint).
- If your bank shows the charge, a credit-card dispute is a fallback — but try the airline refund first; it's faster and keeps your record clean.

05 — Airline Phone / Chat Customer-Service Script

When/how to use this

Use this when you'd rather **call or live-chat** the airline than send a letter — or when a letter went unanswered and you want to push verbally. Read it almost word-for-word. The goal is to stay calm, name the exact rule, and get a **written confirmation and a refund reference number** before you hang up.

Two rules for any call/chat: 1. **Get names and numbers.** Write down the agent's name, the time, and any case/reference number. In chat, **save the transcript**. 2. **Never accept a voucher by accident.** If they offer a travel credit, you must explicitly say you want a refund to your original form of payment, or they may log it as "resolved with a voucher."

What law backs it

Same as the letters: **DOT Automatic Refund Rule (14 CFR Part 260)** for refunds; **14 CFR Part 250** for denied-boarding compensation. You're not arguing — you're citing the rule and asking them to apply it.

SCRIPT — opening (use for any refund situation)

"Hi, my name is [YOUR NAME]. My confirmation code is [CODE]. I'm calling about [flight number, date, route]. The airline [canceled / significantly changed / delayed] this flight [or: didn't provide the Wi-Fi/seat/service I paid for / delivered my checked bag late], and under the DOT Automatic Refund Rule — **14 CFR Part 260** — I'm requesting a **refund to my original form of payment**, not a voucher. Can you process that for me today?"

Then **stop talking** and let them respond.

If they offer a voucher or travel credit

"I appreciate that, but I'm not requesting a voucher or travel credit. Under 14 CFR Part 260, I'm entitled to a refund to my **original form of payment** — the [card / payment method] I used. Please log this as a **refund request to original form of payment**, not a credit."

If they insist a voucher is "all they can do":

"I understand that may be the default offer, but the DOT rule requires a cash-equivalent refund to my original payment method when I decline the alternative. I'm declining the voucher. Please escalate this to someone who can process a refund, or note on my file that I requested one and was refused, with the date and your name."

If they say the change "wasn't significant"

"My **[departure / arrival]** time moved by **[X hours]**. For a **[domestic / international]** flight a significant change is anything more than **[3 hours / 6 hours]**, and mine is past that, so this qualifies. I'm requesting the refund under 14 CFR Part 260."

For a delayed checked bag

"I filed a mishandled-baggage report, reference **[NUMBER]**. My bag arrived **[X hours]** after the flight reached the gate, which is past the DOT cutoff of **[12 hours domestic / 15 hours / 30 hours international]**. Under 14 CFR Part 260 I'm owed a refund of my **checked-bag fee** to my original form of payment. Please process that."

For a paid service not provided (Wi-Fi, seat, boarding)

"I paid **[\$ amount]** for **[service]** and the airline didn't provide it — **[one sentence: 'the Wi-Fi never worked' / 'I was moved out of my paid seat']**. Under 14 CFR Part 260, fees for ancillary services that aren't provided must be refunded to the original form of payment. Please refund **[\$ amount]** to my **[card]**."

For denied boarding / being bumped

"I was **involuntarily denied boarding** on an oversold flight — flight **[number]**, **[date]**. Under **14 CFR Part 250** I'm entitled to **denied-boarding compensation** in cash, separate from any refund. Based on how late I'll reach my destination, that's **[\$1,075 or \$2,150]**. I'd

like that paid by **check or original form of payment today**, and I'm declining any offer to substitute a travel voucher for the cash I'm owed."

(See Asset 07 for the full denied-boarding rules and the written claim.)

Closing every call/chat (do not skip)

"Before we finish: can you confirm the **refund amount**, the **form of payment** it's going back to, and a **reference or case number**? And can you send me a **written confirmation by email**? I have your name as **[AGENT NAME]** and the time as **[TIME]** — thank you."

Then: save the chat transcript or write down the reference number, and log it in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09).

If the call goes nowhere

Politely end it, note what was said and refused, and escalate with the **DOT complaint** (Asset 06). The written record of "I asked, they refused, here's the agent and time" makes the DOT complaint much stronger.

06 — US DOT Complaint Submission Template

When/how to use this

Use this when the airline **stalled, refused, missed the refund deadline, or gave you a voucher you didn't accept**. The U.S. DOT Office of Aviation Consumer Protection takes complaints directly, forwards them to the airline, and **requires the airline to respond**. It's **free**, and airlines take DOT complaints seriously because the DOT tracks and can fine them.

Where to file (free, official): - Online: <https://www.transportation.gov/airconsumer/file-consumer-complaint> (the live DOT complaint portal) - The portal has form fields; the template below is what you paste/adapt into the **"describe your complaint"** narrative box.

Before you file: you should have already contacted the airline once. The DOT process works best as an *escalation*, and the narrative is stronger when you can say "I asked the airline and they refused/ignored me."

What law backs it

The DOT enforces **14 CFR Part 260** (automatic refunds), **14 CFR Part 250** (denied-boarding compensation), and the broader prohibition on **unfair and deceptive practices (49 U.S.C. § 41712)**. You don't have to cite chapter and verse — naming Part 260 / Part 250 and stating plainly what the airline failed to do is enough.

COMPLAINT NARRATIVE (paste into the DOT "description" box)

Complaint type: [Refund — flight cancellation/significant change / Refund — ancillary fee / Refund — checked-bag fee / Denied boarding compensation]

Airline: [AIRLINE NAME] **Confirmation / record locator:** [CODE] **Ticket number:** [13-DIGIT TICKET NUMBER] **Flight:** [FLIGHT NUMBER], [ORIGIN] → [DESTINATION], [DATE]

What happened (facts, in order): On [DATE], [AIRLINE NAME] [canceled / significantly changed by X hours / failed to provide the paid service of ____ / delivered my checked bag X hours late / denied me boarding on an oversold flight]. [One or two plain sentences of detail.]

I did not accept rebooking, a voucher, or a travel credit. I requested a refund to my original form of payment, [\$ AMOUNT] paid by [ORIGINAL FORM OF PAYMENT].

What I did to resolve it: On [DATE] I contacted [AIRLINE NAME] via [phone / chat / their refund form] and requested the refund under 14 CFR Part 260. [The airline refused / offered only a voucher / did not respond / has now exceeded the required refund timeframe of 7 business days]

for credit-card payment / 20 calendar days for other payment.] [If you have it: I spoke with agent "[NAME]" at [TIME] on [DATE], case reference [NUMBER].]

The rule the airline did not follow: Under the DOT Automatic Refund Rule (**14 CFR Part 260**), the airline is required to issue an automatic refund to my original form of payment — not a voucher — within 7 business days (credit card) or 20 calendar days (other payment). [For denied boarding, cite **14 CFR Part 250** and the \$1,075 / \$2,150 compensation amounts instead.] That has not happened.

What I am asking for: A full refund of **[\$ AMOUNT]** to my original form of payment **[card / method]**, [plus denied-boarding compensation of \$[1,075 / 2,150] if applicable], and written confirmation.

Attachments uploaded: [booking/receipt], [the cancellation or schedule-change notice], [my refund request to the airline + their response or proof of non-response], [bag report / Wi-Fi failure / seat documentation as applicable].

Contact info the DOT form will ask for

- Full name, mailing address, email, phone.
- Whether you've contacted the airline (answer **yes** and attach proof).
- The airline name and flight details above.

After you file

- The DOT sends your complaint to the airline and gives it a tracking number. **Save it** and log it in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09), status = "DOT filed."
- The airline must respond to you and to the DOT. Most refund cases that were being ignored get resolved at this stage.
- Keep all correspondence. If the airline still refuses despite a clear Part 260/250 obligation, the DOT complaint is on record and contributes to enforcement.

07 — Denied-Boarding / Bumping Compensation Claim Letter

When/how to use this

Use this when you were **involuntarily denied boarding** ("bumped") from an **oversold** flight — meaning the airline sold more seats than it had and you didn't get on, against your will. This is one of the few situations where U.S. law owes you a **fixed cash payment**, on top of (not instead of) refunding or rebooking you.

Key points: - This is for **involuntary** bumping. If you **volunteered** to give up your seat for a deal you negotiated, that's a separate voluntary arrangement and these fixed amounts don't apply. - The airline must give you a **written statement** of your denied-boarding rights at the gate. If they didn't, note that. - The compensation is based on **how late the airline gets you to your final destination** versus your original arrival.

How much you're owed (effective January 22, 2025):

How late you arrive at your destination	Compensation
Domestic: rerouted to arrive 1–2 hours late · International: 1–4 hours late	200% of your one-way fare, up to \$1,075
Domestic: arrive more than 2 hours late · International: more than 4 hours late	400% of your one-way fare, up to \$2,150
Airline gets you there with 0–1 hour delay	No mandatory cash compensation

You **also** keep your right to a refund or to be rebooked — the bumping payment is separate. And the airline generally must pay you **on the day and at the place** the bumping occurred (by check or original payment).

What law backs it

14 CFR Part 250 (Oversales), § 250.5. Involuntary denied-boarding compensation caps are **\$1,075** (shorter delay) and **\$2,150** (longer delay), effective **January 22, 2025** (inflation-adjusted from the prior \$775 / \$1,550). The payment is in **cash or check**, not a voucher, unless you voluntarily accept a substitute.

LETTER

To: [AIRLINE NAME] — Customer Relations **Submitted via:** [AIRLINE OFFICIAL FORM URL] and [EMAIL] **Date:** [DATE]

Passenger name: [YOUR FULL NAME] **Confirmation / record locator:** [CODE] **Ticket number:** [13-DIGIT TICKET NUMBER]

Bumping details: - Flight I was denied boarding on: [FLIGHT NUMBER], [ORIGIN] → [DESTINATION], [DATE] (this was a [☐ domestic / ☐ international] flight) - I had a **confirmed reservation** and met the check-in / boarding deadline: [YES — time I checked in: ____] - Denial was **involuntary** (I did not volunteer): YES - Original scheduled arrival at my final destination: [DATE/TIME] - Actual / rebooked arrival at my final destination: [DATE/TIME] → I arrived [**X hours**] late - One-way fare for this segment: [**\$ AMOUNT**]

To whom it may concern,

On the flight above, I held a confirmed reservation, met all check-in and boarding deadlines, and was **involuntarily denied boarding** because the flight was oversold. Under **14 CFR Part 250**, I am entitled to **denied-boarding compensation**.

The airline rerouted me to arrive [**X hours**] later than my original scheduled arrival at my final destination. Based on that delay:

[CHOOSE ONE:] - This was a [**domestic flight, arriving 1–2 hours late**] / [**international flight, arriving 1–4 hours late**], so I am owed **200% of my one-way fare, capped at \$1,075**. Two hundred percent of my one-way fare of [\$ AMOUNT] is [**\$ 2× FARE**]; the amount due is the lesser of that and \$1,075 = [**\$ AMOUNT DUE**]. - This was a [**domestic flight, arriving more than 2 hours late**] / [**international flight, arriving more than 4 hours late**], so I am owed **400% of my one-way fare, capped at \$2,150**. Four hundred percent of my one-way fare of [\$ AMOUNT] is [**\$ 4× FARE**]; the amount due is the lesser of that and \$2,150 = [**\$ AMOUNT DUE**].

This compensation is **separate** from my ticket — I [kept my ticket and was rebooked / am separately requesting a refund of the unused portion under 14 CFR Part 260]. The denied-boarding compensation is owed in **cash or check**, and I am declining any offer to substitute a travel voucher for the amount I am owed.

[If applicable: I was not provided the written statement of denied-boarding rights required under 14 CFR Part 250 at the gate.]

Please issue payment of [**\$ AMOUNT DUE**] by check or to my original form of payment, and confirm in writing.

Sincerely,

[YOUR FULL NAME] [YOUR EMAIL] [YOUR PHONE] [YOUR MAILING ADDRESS]

Attachments: [boarding pass / confirmed reservation], [proof of check-in time], [the rebooking showing your actual arrival time], [any written denied-boarding notice the airline gave you].

After you send it

- If the airline tried to pay you with a **voucher at the gate**, you can still insist on cash/check — accepting a voucher should be voluntary, not a default.
- The amount is based on your **one-way fare** for the bumped segment and the **delay to your final destination**, capped at \$1,075 / \$2,150. Show your math in the letter (above) so there's nothing to argue about.
- Log it in the Claim Tracker (Asset 09). Refusal or silence → Asset 06 (DOT complaint, citing 14 CFR Part 250).

08 — EU261 Claim Letter (Transatlantic Flights)

When/how to use this

Use this when your flight was **delayed 3+ hours on arrival, canceled, or you were denied boarding**, AND the flight is covered by EU Regulation 261/2004. This is a separate, often larger, money lever than the U.S. DOT rules — and it can apply to the same flight.

Is your flight covered? EU261 applies to: - Any flight departing an EU/EEA airport — on any airline, including U.S. carriers. (e.g., Paris → New York on Delta: **covered**.) - A flight arriving in the EU/EEA only if operated by an EU/"Community" carrier. (e.g., New York → Paris on Air France: **covered**.)

Not covered: A flight from a non-EU airport on a non-EU airline, even if it lands in the EU. (e.g., New York → Paris on United or Delta: **NOT covered** by EU261 — use the DOT assets instead.)

Quick test for transatlantic: **Departing Europe? Always covered. Flying into Europe? Only if it's a European airline.**

Send to the **operating airline's** EU claims / customer-relations address. Many EU carriers have a dedicated EU261 / "passenger rights" online form — use it if available, and email a copy.

What law backs it

Regulation (EC) No 261/2004, as interpreted by the Court of Justice of the EU (the *Sturgeon* and *Nelson* rulings, which extended cash compensation to long delays of **3+ hours at the final destination**). These rules remain in force in 2026; reform has been discussed but **not** enacted. Compensation is fixed by distance:

Flight distance	Compensation
1,500 km or less	€250
1,500–3,500 km (and intra-EU over 1,500 km)	€400
Over 3,500 km (typical transatlantic)	€600

The airline can avoid compensation only by proving **"extraordinary circumstances"** that couldn't have been avoided even with all reasonable measures (e.g., severe weather, air-traffic-control strikes, security risks). Ordinary technical faults, staffing, and routine operational problems do **not** qualify. Compensation is owed *on top of* your right to a refund or rerouting.

(If your flight departed from or was on a UK carrier into the UK, the equivalent law is "UK261" — same structure, amounts set in GBP by the UK Civil Aviation Authority. Use the same letter and

replace the citation with "UK Regulation (the retained version of EC 261/2004)".)

LETTER

To: [AIRLINE NAME] — Passenger Rights / EU261 Claims **Submitted via:** [AIRLINE EU261 CLAIM FORM URL] and [CUSTOMER-RELATIONS EMAIL] **Date:** [DATE]

Passenger name(s): [YOUR FULL NAME(S), as on the ticket] **Booking reference / PNR:** [6-CHARACTER CODE] **Ticket number(s):** [13-DIGIT NUMBER(S)]

Flight details: - Route: [ORIGIN AIRPORT] → [DESTINATION AIRPORT] - Operating carrier: [AIRLINE NAME] (the airline that actually flew the plane) - Flight number: [FLIGHT NUMBER] - Scheduled date: [DATE] - What happened: [☐ delayed 3+ hrs on arrival / ☐ canceled / ☐ denied boarding] - Scheduled arrival time: [TIME] — Actual arrival time: [TIME] — **Delay: [X hours Y minutes]** - Great-circle distance of the flight: [APPROX KM — e.g., New York–Paris ≈ 5,840 km]

To the operating carrier,

I am claiming compensation under **Regulation (EC) No 261/2004** for the flight identified above.

This flight is within the scope of the Regulation because it [☐ departed from an airport located in the EU/EEA / ☐ arrived in the EU/EEA and was operated by an EU/Community carrier].

The flight was [delayed by [X hours] at the final destination / canceled / I was denied boarding]. Under Article 7 of the Regulation, and the Court of Justice of the EU's rulings in *Sturgeon* (C-402/07) and *Nelson* (C-581/10) establishing that delays of three hours or more at the final destination give rise to the same compensation as a cancellation, I am entitled to fixed compensation.

The flight distance is over 3,500 km, so the compensation due is **€600 per passenger** under Article 7(1)(c). [If your flight is a shorter band, replace with: "The flight distance is [X] km, so the compensation due is €[250/400] per passenger under Article 7(1)([a/b])."]

Number of passengers on this booking: [N] **Total compensation claimed: €[AMOUNT] (€[PER-PERSON] × [N] passengers).**

This compensation is separate from, and in addition to, any refund or rerouting I am entitled to. I am not aware of any extraordinary circumstances under Article 5(3) that would relieve you of this obligation. If you intend to rely on the extraordinary-circumstances defense, please provide, in writing, the specific cause of the disruption and the evidence that it could not have been avoided even if all reasonable measures had been taken.

Please pay the compensation due to the following: - Payment method: [BANK TRANSFER / ORIGINAL CARD / CHEQUE] - Details: [IBAN / ACCOUNT / ADDRESS as needed]

Please respond within 14 days. If I do not receive payment or a substantiated extraordinary-circumstances explanation, I will escalate to the relevant national enforcement body (NEB) for the country of departure and, if necessary, pursue the claim through the courts or an alternative dispute resolution (ADR) scheme.

Yours faithfully,

[YOUR FULL NAME] [YOUR EMAIL] [YOUR PHONE] [YOUR MAILING ADDRESS]

Attached: [boarding pass(es) / booking confirmation / proof of actual arrival time / any delay notification from the airline]

After you send it

- **The clock and the threshold are everything.** Compensation hinges on the **actual arrival delay at your final destination** (gate/door open), not the departure delay. Save proof of when you actually arrived.
- **Don't accept a voucher as "compensation."** EU261 compensation is a cash payment. A meal voucher or travel credit is not a substitute.
- **If they claim "extraordinary circumstances,"** make them prove it in writing and name the cause. Weather and ATC strikes can qualify; a late inbound aircraft or a routine technical fault usually does not.
- **If ignored or refused:** escalate to the **National Enforcement Body** in the departure country (each EU state has one), or use the airline's ADR scheme. You have years to claim in most EU states (the limitation period is set by national law, often 2–6 years).
- You can pursue **both** an EU261 claim *and* a U.S. DOT refund where both apply — they cover different things (compensation vs. refund of what you paid).

09 — Claim Tracker

When/how to use this

Use this for **every** claim you file, from the moment you send the first letter or make the first call. It keeps each claim's facts, the law behind it, the dollars owed, the deadline, and where it stands — so nothing slips past a deadline and every escalation is backed by a clean record.

A companion **claim-tracker.csv** ships with this kit. Open it in Excel, Google Sheets, or Numbers and fill one row per claim. The Markdown table below is the same thing if you'd rather keep it in a notes app.

How to fill each column

Column	What goes here
Flight / Booking	Route + date + record locator (e.g., "JFK → CDG 6/14, PNR ABC123").
Issue	One of: Cancellation · Significant change · Bag delay · Ancillary fee · Denied boarding/bumping · EU261 delay.
Law / Asset	The rule you're using + which asset you sent (e.g., "14 CFR 260 / Asset 01"; "14 CFR 250 / Asset 07"; "EC 261/2004 / Asset 08").
\$ / € Owed	The amount you're claiming. For bumping, show 200% or 400% of one-way fare up to the \$1,075 / \$2,150 cap. For EU261, €250/€400/€600. For refunds, the amount you paid.
Date Filed	The date you sent the letter or filed the form.
Deadline	When the airline must act. Refunds: +7 business days (credit card) or +20 calendar days (other). EU261: a reasonable 14 days to respond. Write the actual calendar date.
Status	Open · Awaiting response · Refund issued · Escalated to DOT · Escalated to NEB · Paid · Denied · Closed.
Next step / Notes	Agent name + time of any call, voucher offers you declined, confirmation/reference numbers, and the next action.

Tracker table

Flight / Booking	Issue	Law / Asset	\$ / € Owed	Date Filed	Deadline	Status	Next step / Notes
[JFK → CDG 6/14, ABC123]	[Cancellation]	[14 CFR 260 / Asset 01]	[\$642.00]	[2026-06-14]	[2026-06-23]	[Awaiting response]	[Declined voucher in writing. Conf #R-88231.]

Flight / Booking	Issue	Law / Asset	\$ / € Owed	Date Filed	Deadline	Status	Next step / Notes

Deadline cheat-sheet (so you can fill the column fast)

Claim type	Airline's deadline to act	Where it comes from
Refund (credit card)	7 business days from when the refund became due	14 CFR Part 260 (DOT 2024 rule)
Refund (other payment)	20 calendar days	14 CFR Part 260
Bag fee refund	Bag fee owed once bag is 12+ hrs late domestic / 15–30 hrs international ; refund then due on the 7/20-day timeline	14 CFR § 260.4
Ancillary fee refund	Due once the service is confirmed not provided; 7/20-day timeline	14 CFR § 260.3
Denied-boarding comp	Airline must pay on the day and at the airport if possible; otherwise promptly	14 CFR Part 250
EU261 compensation	No fixed statutory clock; 14 days is a reasonable demand ; you have years to claim	EC 261/2004 + national law

Escalation reminder

When a deadline passes with no resolution, change **Status** to "Escalated to DOT" and file **Asset 06**. For EU261, escalate to the departure country's **National Enforcement Body**. A filled-in tracker row is most of what you need to do it — it already has the flight, the law, the amount, and the dates.

Claim Tracker (importable spreadsheet)

This table is also provided as an editable .csv you can import into Google Sheets, Excel, or Notion.

Flight / Booking	Issue	Law / Asset	Amount Owed	Date Filed	Deadline	Status	Next step / Notes
JFK->CDG 6/14, ABC123	Cancellation	14 CFR 260 / Asset 01	\$642.00	2026- 06-14	2026-06- 23	Awaiting response	Declined voucher in writing. Conf #R-88231.

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